Notes from Underground to 1984

by way of We and Brave New World

THE OUTLIER'S FATE



Ignored
Notes from Underground (1864)

Diagnosed
We (1920–21)

Removed
Brave New World (1932)

Hunted, broken, rebuilt
1984 (1949)

Class 2 of “Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age”

TONIGHT

Road Map

- **Table of Context** Four books, four authors, four fates
- **Where we left off** The Underground Man, an outlier no one bothers to control
- **Two stepping stones** Zamyatin's We and Huxley's Brave New World
- **1984 through two lenses** Disciplinary Surveillance and Narrative Analysis (from the Preface reading)
- **Fromm's Afterword** Can the longing for freedom be stamped out?

Table of Context

Book	Author	Written	Country	Influences	System	Defiance	Treatment
Notes from Underground	Fyodor Dostoevsky	1863–64	Russia	Chernyshevsky's What Is to Be Done?, Russian nihilism, Siberian prison and exile	Rational egoism	Spite	**Ignored**
We	Yevgeny Zamyatin	1920–21	Russia	Bolshevik turned Soviet dissident; Scientific Management (Taylorism); H. G. Wells	Clockwork efficiency	A soul	**Cured**
Brave New World	Aldous Huxley	1931	England	WWI, pacifism, utopian visions, behavioral psychology, eugenics, consumerism	Hedonism	Questioning	**Removed**
1984	George Orwell	1944–48	England	Burma, Spanish Civil War, WWII, fascism, communism, Zamyatin's We, tuberculosis	State ownership, even of thought	Longing	**Crushed**

Wikipedia: Notes from Underground · We · Brave New World · 1984 · Dostoevsky · Zamyatin · Huxley · Orwell
What inspired them: Brave New World · 1984

The Outlier Ignored

No room for him

- He warns that reason would make men into piano keys
  - 2 + 2 = 4, forced on us from outside
- He is an outlier society has no room for
  - His schoolmates ignore him or laugh at him

Trapped in himself

- He watches and persecutes himself
  - "Acute consciousness" audits every gesture
- His defiance — spite, perversity — is entirely private
- He argues against rational egoism…
  - …but can't escape the cave of his own ego
  - He cannot accept love (Liza)

Outlier Diagnosed → Outlier Removed

Zamyatin's We

written 1920–21; English 1924

- A city of glass: the rational utopia Dostoevsky mocked
- D-503: mathematician, model citizen
- Glass apartments; citizens inform as a civic duty
- He grows a "soul" — 2 + 2 = 4 isn't all there is
- Treated as an illness; the Great Operation removes imagination

Huxley's Brave New World

1932

- Conditioning installs the watcher before birth
- A dystopia of pleasure: free sex and soma
- Bernard and Helmholtz push at the cracks — sent to islands
- John the Savage claims "the right to be unhappy" — the Underground Man's argument, reborn

Fromm's contrast: We and 1984 rule by terror plus manipulation; Brave New World by mass suggestion, with no need for terror.

From Self-Watching to Big Brother Watching

Outward

- Telescreens, Thought Police, children who inform
- Big Brother: always watching, listening, controlling
- The Party cannot tolerate a single Underground Man

Back inward (the Panopticon)

- Never knowing when you're watched, you watch yourself
- Winston polices his face, sleep-talk, handwriting
- By the end, his own monitor — on the Party's behalf

Staged shunning: Goldstein is a manufactured outlier; the Two Minutes Hate is society's rejection performed as daily ritual.

The image: *the Underground Man's inner critic was his own — the Party takes it over.*

1:12:18 Telescreen reveal: "We are the dead"

0:27:19 "War is peace…" — the Party slogans

Newspeak: Controlling the Story

Underground Man
writes to "gentlemen" who may not exist

D-503
writes to unknown readers on other planets

Winston
writes his diary to the future

Each journal is where the self survives — and each state wants it closed

Newspeak makes the diary impossible
Shrink the vocabulary until disloyal thoughts can't be formed. The Underground Man resists by never stopping talking; Orwell imagines a regime that removes the words.

The 2 + 2 inversion
Dostoevsky: defy 2 × 2 = 4 — reason is the tyrant
Orwell: cling to 2 + 2 = 4 — reality is under attack

0:06:16 "Think in Newspeak..."

0:10:31 Winston's diary: "From a dead man, greetings"

Applied to Winston

Canonical script	The Party's version of how to think, act, and remember
Breach	The first word Winston writes in the diary
Intentional states	His private thoughts — the one place the telescreen can't see, until Room 101
Narrative vs. systemic truth	Winston's memory against the Ministry of Truth and the memory hole
Accrual	Can private defiance add up to a movement? Julia, the Brotherhood, Goldstein's book — and why none of it accrues

0:00:01 "Who controls the past controls the future..."

1:24:43 "Reality is in the human mind..."

FROMM'S AFTERWORD

Can a Boot Stamp on a Human Face Forever?

Central question
Can human nature be changed so we forget our longing for freedom, dignity, and love?

Severity proves strength
A brain operation (We), drugs and breeding (BNW), unlimited torture (1984) — the cure shows how strong the striving is

The minority of one
When truth is whatever the Party says, a minority of one must believe he is insane — the outlier lens returns

Doublethink is not just "them"
Fromm insists 1984 "means us, too"

Fromm's hope
A fully dehumanized world would be a world of madmen — not a viable one

Fromm's ending ▸

1:29:32 O'Brien on power

1:30:53 Boot on the face

1:37:19 Room 101

Ending of Fromm's Afterword

I am sure that neither Orwell nor Huxley or Zamyatin wanted to insist that this world of insanity is bound to come. On the contrary, it was quite obviously their intention to sound a warning by showing where we are headed for unless we succeed in a renaissance of the spirit of humanism and dignity which is at the very roots of Occidental culture. Orwell, as well as the two other authors, is simply implying that the new form of managerial industrialism, in which man builds machines which act like men and develops men who act like machines, is conducive to an era of dehumanization and complete alienation, in which men are transformed into things and become appendices to the process of production and consumption. All three authors imply that this danger exists not only in Communism of the Russian or Chinese versions, but that it is a danger inherent in the modern mode of production and organization, and relatively independent of the various ideologies. Orwell, like the authors of the other negative Utopias, is not a prophet of disaster. He wants to warn and to awaken us. He still hopes — but in contrast to the writers of the Utopias in the earlier phases of Western society, his hope is a desperate one. The hope can be realized only by recognizing, so 1984 teaches us, the danger with which all men are confronted today, the danger of a society of automatons who will have lost every trace of individuality, of love, of critical thought, and yet who will not be aware of it because of “doublethink”.

Books like Orwell’s are powerful warnings, and it would be most unfortunate if the reader smugly interpreted 1984 as another description of Stalinist barbarism, and if he does not see that it means us, too.

— Erich Fromm, Afterword to 1984 (1961) · click to close

THE THROUGH-LINE

Control Dressed as Care

No controller

The Underground Man has no one who pretends to love him

Happiness for freedom

Zamyatin's Benefactor and Huxley's Mustapha Mond make the trade

Caring face, no promise

"Big Brother" is family language; O'Brien, tender in Room 101, says he is curing Winston

Fromm: O'Brien is Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor — except the Party no longer even pretends to make people happy.

0:39:00 "...the place where there is no darkness"

Questions for the Room

1. The Underground Man was ignored; Winston is watched every minute. Which is lonelier?
2. Is secret writing to an unknown reader a kind of freedom? What happens when the words are taken away?
3. Can a society force 2 + 2 to equal 4, or 5 — or make it not matter at all?
4. Are you an outlier? Would you rather be ignored, diagnosed, removed, or hunted, broken, and rebuilt?
5. From Fromm: do severe methods prove the strength of what they suppress — or make the defiant stronger?
6. From the homework: is history written by the victors? Is truth written by those in power?

What Comes Next: The Matrix



Blue pill

Unknowingly accept a virtual reality



Red pill

See the truth — even 2 + 2 = 4 is just code underneath: 10 + 10 = 100 in binary

The controller changes again: the Architect doesn't watch you or break you — he builds the world you live in.

Scene Index

0:00:01 "Who controls the past controls the future..."

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